Nalini shouted for husband Murugan. Getting no response, she started screaming, ‘The atrocities of the IPKF are back! The atrocities of the IPKF are back!’ Murugan heard this from the adjoining room and gave in. He shouted back from his room, ‘Come here! I will tell you what you want to know. There is no need to harass a woman.’

Raju arranged the names of the assassins in order of their arrest—Ravi Shankar, followed by Haribabu’s girlfriend Sundari, then Bhagyanathan, Padma, Nalini and Murugan. Verma and Ragothaman spoke to Ravi Shankar. Kanth and Raju took charge of Bhagyanathan. Over time, the four officers took turns to interrogate all the six with a clear-cut message—either they cooperated with the investigation or got killed in encounters. They might have succeeded in their mission of assassinating a world leader but they were very small when it came to the state machinery. The choice was theirs.

Sundari didn’t have much to add. She had been in custody for more than ten days. Bhagyanathan and Nalini’s mother Padma offered no resistance and answered every question. Ravi Shankar, too, came clean easily. Bhagyanathan had started cooperating, seeing his sister and mother in custody. It was Nalini who had asked for a lawyer, to which she was told it was not the United States. Murugan got the message before she did—he started answering the SIT’s questions.

Even as the gang started spilling the beans, Anirudhya’s contacts and friends in the SIT tried to piece together the outlines of the conspiracy that killed Rajiv Gandhi.

Ravi Shankar disclosed that key LTTE operative Muthuraja and ideologue Baby Subramaniam, both trusted lieutenants of Prabhakaran, met Bhagyanathan at photographer Shubha Sundaram’s studio. Ragothaman and Verma confronted Bhagyanathan about it.

Bhagyanathan revealed that he wanted to edit journals voicing the Tamil cause and the policy of the Indian authorities that did precious little for